



majority of what is left is farmed. This means that a huge amount of the population live in urban areas. Japan is still a country of remarkable ethnic and cultural purity. Non-Japanese people make up only one percent of

the population. The cities of Japan are busy with traffic and industry but old traditions still survive and deep-rooted appreciation of traditional arts flourishes throughout Japan, from the tea ceremonies to sumo wrestling.

Traditional Japan

Japan's oldest religion is Shinto, and most Japanese still observe Shinto rituals alongside Buddhist practices. Manners and customs are of utmost importance in Japan, and the old respect and humility are practiced in the home as well as in the modern office.



TEA CEREMONY

The Japanese tea ceremony, or *chanoyu*, was established in the 16th century and is much the same today. It is the ritual way of preparing and drinking green tea and is considered an art as well as a way to purify the soul.



STREET FESTIVALS

The Japanese celebrate a huge number of festivals, many of which include street parades, such as this one. In May, when the spectacular "Children's Day" is celebrated, colorful carp banners are flown.



KIMONO

The kimono is the traditional dress of Japan. Today, Japanese women rarely wear kimonos except on special occasions, such as weddings. Children's kimonos are similar to the adults ones but often much brighter in color.

Because of the complex material shape, it can take an hour or more to dress a child in a kimono.

SAPPORO SNOW FESTIVAL

The Sapporo Snow Festival is one of Japan's largest winter events. For seven days in February the main street in Susukino is transformed into a myriad of ice sculptures and ice buildings. Many countries take part in the ice-sculpting competition.

